free and open Indo-Pacific. Even a moderate thaw in US–Russia relations could give India greater room to manoeuvre in its relations with Russia. This configuration may also enable Russia to play a more independent role in the Indo-Pacific rather than as an adjunct to Chinese interests.

Conclusion

India and Russia continue to reaffirm the relevance and strength of their strategic partnership through regular summits, close interactions of their leaders, and a range of agreements for bilateral and multilateral cooperation. From India's perspective, defence cooperation is important, collaboration in hydrocarbons and nuclear power promotes its energy security, and Russia's political support in international forums is valuable. The India relationship is important for Russia in its effort to burnish its credentials as a great power in a multipolar world. India has to ensure that Russia retains a sufficiently strong stake in relations to withstand pressures from China to act against India's political and security interests. Russia's concept of a "Greater Eurasia" accords with India's effort to promote a cooperative architecture in the Indo-Pacific, warding off the prospect of a Chinese hegemony.

The extent to which these strands can be taken forward will depend on the geometry of the US–Russia–China triangle. To revert to the analogy of Ambassador Fu Ying, a greater distance between Washington and Beijing and a somewhat shorter distance between Washington and Moscow may create sufficient distance between Moscow and Beijing to enable Russia to reduce the inequality of its partnership with China. This, in turn, may enable India to sustain strategic partnerships with both Russia and the